Module 3

Keralam during Early Historic (300 BCE- 500 CE)

Part I

Early Tamil Literature

Sangam literature denotes the earliest body of Tamil literary works, composed approximately between 300 BCE and 300 CE in ancient South India. It is considered as a main source of evidence for understanding the Early historic period of the region. Originated as oral bardic poetry of the ancient Tamils, it was compiled in written form in the later period. The early Sangam texts provide valuable insights into the social, cultural, political, and literary life of ancient South India.

According to Tamil tradition, there existed three Sangams (assemblies of poets), collectively known as *Muchchangam*, in ancient Tamil Nadu. These literary academies flourished under the patronage of the Pandya dynasty. Each Sangam is believed to have lasted for several thousand years. These assemblies functioned as scholarly gatherings where poets composed, presented, and evaluated literary works.

Sangam poetry is broadly classified into two major thematic categories: Akam and Puram. *Akam* poetry deals with inner or personal emotions, particularly love and relationships, and is represented in works such as Akananuru and Kurunthogai. In contrast, *Puram* poetry focuses on external or public life,

including themes of war, heroism, kingship, and honour, as seen in Purananuru and Pathitrupathu.

The major literary works associated with this period include Pathinenmelkanakku and Pathinenkilkanakku, along with the grammatical treatise Tolkappiyam. Additionally, two important Tamil epics—Silappathikaram, written by Ilango Adigal, and Manimegalai, authored by Sattanar—are closely related in narrative and are counted among the Five Great Epics of Tamil literature.

Pathinenmelkanakku refers to a collection of eighteen classical Tamil works, which include the Ettuthokai (Eight Anthologies) and Pattuppattu (Ten Idylls). These texts primarily reflect themes of love, war, and social life, rather than being purely didactic in nature.

On the other hand, Pathinenkilkanakku, meaning "Eighteen Lesser Texts," is a collection of post-Sangam didactic works that emphasize ethics, moral values, righteous living, and social discipline. The most notable text in this group is Thirukkural, composed by Thiruvalluvar. It is considered as one of the most important works of Tamil literature. It consists of 1,330 couplets (kurals) organized into three major sections: *Aram* (virtue), *Porul* (wealth), and *Inbam* (love). The text presents universal moral principles, emphasizing righteousness, social responsibility, and personal conduct. Its concise poetic form combines simplicity with profound philosophical insight, making it accessible across cultures and time periods. Thirukkural continues to be a foundational work for ethical thought and literary excellence in Tamil tradition and beyond

Tolkappiyam is the earliest extant work of Tamil grammar and poetics, traditionally attributed to Tolkappiyar and dated to the early centuries of the Sangam literature period. Comprising three sections—*Ezhuttatikaram* (phonology and orthography), *Sollatikaram* (morphology and syntax), and

Porulatikaram (semantics and literary conventions)—the text systematically codifies the structure of the Tamil language while also elaborating the aesthetic principles governing classical Tamil poetry. Notably, the *Porulatikaram* delineates the conceptual division between *akam* (interior/subjective themes) and *puram* (exterior/public themes), providing a theoretical framework that underpins much of Sangam literature. As both a grammatical treatise and a work of literary theory, Tolkappiyam remains foundational for the study of classical Tamil language, poetics, and cultural history.

Akananuru is one of the major anthologies of the Ettuthokai corpus in Sangam literature. It contains 400 poems and belongs to the "akam" (interior) genre. It emphasises on various topics such as love, emotion, and personal relationships rather than public or heroic life. The poems are attributed to multiple poets, reflecting a rich diversity of voices and regional perspectives within early Tamil society. The anthology is structured according to the classical Tamil poetic convention of *tinai* (landscape) such as mountains, forests, seashores, and arid lands.

Akananuru is a valuable source for understanding the cultural, social, and psychological dimensions of early historic South India. The poems reveal nuanced insights into gender roles, moral values, and social norms, particularly in relation to love and family life.

Purananuru is one of the prominent anthologies of the Ettuthokai within Sangam literature. Belongs to the "puram" (exterior) genre, it incorporates 400 poems. Purananuru deals with themes of public life such as war, kingship, valor, ethics, and social responsibility. The poems were composed by wide range of poets, including men and women from diverse social backgrounds. It offers a broad and

inclusive perspective on early Tamil society. Unlike akam poetry, which is symbolic and interior, Purananuru poems are often direct and descriptive, celebrating heroic deeds, commemorating fallen warriors, and praising the generosity and virtues of rulers and chieftains.

Purananuru provides valuable informations in understanding the political and social landscape of ancient Tamilakam. The anthology provides detailed insights into warfare, governance, economic practices, and the code of honor that guided both rulers and warriors. It also reflects ethical concerns like the duties of kings, and the importance of patronage in sustaining poets and bards.

Patittuppattu is one of the classical anthologies of the Ettuthokai within the corpus of Sangam literature. The title literally means "Ten Tens," referring to its original structure of ten groups of ten poems, each dedicated to a Chera ruler. Although only eight decades survive today, the work remains a significant source for understanding the political and cultural history of the Chera dynasty. The poems are composed by various poets including one woman who praise the valor, generosity, and achievements of Chera kings, presenting them as ideal rulers within the puram (public life) poetic tradition. The anthology provides detailed references to royal patronage, warfare, trade, and diplomatic relations, including contacts with distant regions.

Part II

Tinai and the cultural landscape of early Tamizhakam

Early Tamil songs provide detailed information about the geographical groupings. The concept of *tinai* stands as the most significant feature of these anthologies. The *tinai* (landscape classification) is a foundational element of

Sangam literature and reflects the close connection between nature and human life in early Tamilakam. Tinai classifies the natural environment into five primary landscapes—*kurinji* (mountain), *mullai* (forest), *marutam* (agricultural plains), *neital* (seashore), and *palai* (arid land). These categories are associated with specific emotions, deities, occupations, flora, fauna, and social practices. This is not merely geographical but symbolic, as each landscape corresponds to particular themes in *akam* (interior) poetry.

According to Rajan Gurukkal and Raghava Varier, *tinai* "is not a rigid physiographic compartmentalisation of the nature into five segments. Where exactly one *tinai* begins and where it ends cannot be demarcated since each one merges with the other". P.T. Srinivasa Iyengar connects the dissemination of *tinai* with the progression of civilisation. Kamil Zvelebil consider the geographical division as the historical migration of pre- Dravidian and proto- Tamil populations movement and resettlement in diverse regions.

In Sangam literature, *Kurinji* (mountain landscape) is one of the five major *tinai* classifications. The landscape is characterized by hills, waterfalls, dense forests, and the blooming kurinji flower, which serves as a key ecological marker. The people of this region are typically hunters and hill tribes such as Kuravar, Vettuvar, Kanavar etc:- Their presiding deity is Murugan that reflects the spiritual dimension of the landscape.

Mullai (forest or pastoral landscape) is another major *tinai* classifications. Its landscape is characterized by forests, pastoral lands, grazing cattle, and a tranquil natural environment that reflects calmness and endurance. The inhabitants are typically pastoral communities such as Ayar, Itaiyar, Kovalar etc:- Their presiding deity is Mayon, indicating the spiritual associations of the region.

Marutam (agricultural plains) is associated with fertile riverine regions and settled agrarian life. The landscape is characterized by lush paddy fields, irrigation systems, and prosperous villages sustained by agriculture. The inhabitants are mainly farmers and cultivators known as Ulavar, Uzhathiyar, Vellalar etc:- Their presiding deity was Indra, symbolizing fertility and abundance.

Neital (seashore landscape) is one of the five *tinai* divisions associated with coastal ecology and maritime life. The landscape is characterized by sandy shores, waves, salt pans, and fishing settlements that reflect an active coastal economy. The inhabitants are mainly fishermen, salt-makers, and seafarers called as Parathavar, Nulaiyar, Umanar,Alavar and Valayar. Their presiding deity was Varuna, symbolizing the vast and unpredictable nature of the ocean.

Palai (arid land) is one of the five *tinai* landscapes associated with harsh, dry, and desolate environments. Unlike the other landscapes, Palai is not a natural ecological zone but is formed when fertile lands such as *kurinji* or *mullai* become parched under extreme heat. The region is characterized by scarcity of water, barren terrain, and perilous routes inhabited by bandits and wayfarers, and its presiding deity is Korravai. Maravar, Kalvar and Eyinar were the major groups lived in the palai tinai.

From a cultural perspective, the tinai system provides valuable insights into the socio-economic and belief systems of early Tamil society. It reflects how communities adapted to their environments, with occupations ranging from hunting and pastoralism to agriculture and maritime trade. The association of each landscape with specific deities and customs also reveals the religious and ritualistic dimensions of daily life. Moreover, tinai demonstrates the sophisticated ecological awareness and aesthetic sensibility of ancient Tamil poets, who integrated environment, emotion, and culture into a unified literary framework.

Thus, the concept of tinai serves as both a poetic convention and a cultural map of early Tamilakam.

Part III

Greek Roman Writings: Foreign Trade

The Greco-Roman writings are an important set of evidences for understanding the history of early Keralam. These accounts were composed by various groups such as classical geographers, historians, and merchants. They provide important information on the political organization, trade networks, and socio-economic conditions of the region. One of the most important sources is the *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*, a 1st-century CE navigational manual written by an anonymous Greek merchant. It offers detailed descriptions of maritime routes and ports, including Muziris and Nelcynda, emphasising their eminence as major centers of Indo–Roman trade. It also provides information on the role of ports in the export of luxury commodities including pepper.

Another significant account on the Indo- Roman trade is the *Natural History* by Pliny the Elder. He provides reference on the drain of Roman gold to the East, in exchange for pepper and luxury goods from the region. Similarly, the geographer Claudius Ptolemy, in his *Geographia*, (Geographike Hyphegesis) gives a more systematic account of the geography of South India. It mentions about the place names, trade centers, and inland routes. Eventhough Ptolemy's coordinates for the region are not always geographically correct as per the modern standards, it helps to recognize numerous early settlements and ports in Keralam.

From the Greco-Roman writings, it is evident that Keralam was an important part of the wider Indian Ocean trade network. It is characterized by thriving port cities,

active participation in long-distance commerce, and interaction with foreign merchants, often referred to as “Yavanas.” Along with this references to navigational knowledge, monsoon winds, and seasonal trade cycles underlines the sophistication of maritime practices in the region.

However a critical approach should be applied while using these accounts. In order to overcome the inaccuracies and limitations, these works should be corroborated with archaeological findings such as Roman coins, amphorae, and ceramics and and also with native literary sources like Sangam literature.

Archaeological evidences play an important role in understanding the Greeco-Roman relationship with early Keralam. Evidences such as coins, ceramics and beads are vital in this regard.

Excavations and finding of artifacts along with the literary accounts provide more clarity on the existence of the Indo–Roman trade. Among the most significant site is Pattanam, widely identified with the ancient port of Muziris. Excavations conducted at Pattanam have resulted in the finding of Roman amphora fragments, terra sigillata (Arretine ware), glass beads, and Mediterranean ceramics. All of these thrown light on the existence of contact with the Roman Empire and the integration of the region into long-distance maritime trade networks.

Numismatic evidence forms another crucial category of archaeological data. Large hoards of Roman gold and silver coins, especially those issued during the reigns of emperors such as Augustus and Tiberius, have been discovered across Kerala and adjoining regions. These coins not only attest to the volume of trade but also suggest the accumulation of wealth in local polities, possibly under the aegis of the Chera dynasty. The presence of cut and pierced coins further indicates their adaptation within local exchange systems, pointing to processes of monetization and economic transformation.

Ceramic and artefactual evidence also plays a vital role in reconstructing these interactions. Amphorae—large storage jars used for transporting wine and olive oil—are frequently found in coastal and inland sites, suggesting the import of Mediterranean commodities. Additionally, the discovery of Roman intaglios, glassware, and beads reflects not only trade but also cultural exchange and the circulation of luxury goods. Sites such as Arikamedu, though located outside Kerala, provide comparative material that helps situate Keralam within a broader network of Indo–Mediterranean exchange.

Furthermore, megalithic burials in parts of Kerala have yielded Roman artefacts, indicating the incorporation of foreign goods into local social and ritual contexts. This suggests that imported items were not merely commercial commodities but also markers of status and prestige within early historic societies. The stratigraphic context of these finds demonstrates that such interactions were particularly intense between the 1st century BCE and the 3rd century CE, aligning with the peak of Indo–Roman trade

Part IV

Pattanam and Vizhinjam Excavations

Pattanam

Pattanam is an important archaeological site located in Vadakkekara village in the Ernakulam district of Kerala, India. It is situated in the delta region of the Periyar River and lies about 4 kilometres from the Arabian Sea coast. The site has attracted considerable attention because of its historical significance and its possible connection with the ancient port of Muziris.

The excavations at Pattanam were the first large-scale multidisciplinary archaeological investigations conducted in Kerala. The first phase of excavation

was carried out by the Kerala Council for Historical Research (KCHR) from 18 February to 8 April 2007. This project was undertaken in collaboration with the Archaeological Survey of India, the State Department of Archaeology, and the Tourism and Revenue Departments of the Kerala Government.

The project began with a surface survey aimed at identifying archaeological and historical remains in the region. This was followed by extensive excavations at the Pattanam site. The primary objective was to find archaeological evidence that could help identify the location of the ancient port city of Muziris (Musiri), which is frequently mentioned in classical Indian and foreign sources as an important centre of maritime trade on the Malabar Coast.

Archaeological evidence indicates that Pattanam has a long history of occupation extending over three millennia, from around 1000 BCE to the modern period. The site shows evidence of habitation during the Iron Age, Early Historic, Medieval, and Modern periods. Among these, the Early Historic period (3rd century BCE to 5th century CE) appears to have been the most prosperous and active phase. So far, archaeologists have excavated 60 trenches, covering less than one percent of the total 70-hectare mound.

The excavations have yielded a vast number of artefacts, including pottery, beads, metal objects, and imported goods. Thousands of pottery fragments and artefacts originating from regions such as the Mediterranean, Egypt, the Red Sea, West Asia, and the South China Sea have been discovered. Important finds include Roman amphorae, sphinx seals, and fine glassware, demonstrating Pattanam's extensive overseas trade connections.

The site has also produced valuable botanical remains such as rice, black pepper, cardamom, frankincense, charcoal, seeds, wood, and pulses. These remains provide important information about the agricultural practices, diet, and trade

commodities of the inhabitants. Zoological remains, including animal bones and teeth, help researchers understand the dietary habits and environment of the region. Geological evidence consists of both local and imported stones and rocks.

Several architectural features discovered at Pattanam indicate the presence of an urban settlement nearly 2,000 years ago. These include well-made burnt bricks, roofing tiles, ring wells, toilet structures, and planned building layouts. Excavations have also uncovered a wharf with bollards and a six-metre-long wooden canoe, suggesting the existence of harbour facilities and active maritime activities.

The industrial character of Pattanam is reflected in evidence of specialised crafts and technologies such as metallurgy, bead-making, cotton weaving, and terracotta production. The scale of these activities suggests a thriving economic centre engaged in both local production and international trade.

The geographical location of Pattanam and the wide range of artefacts recovered from the site strongly support the view that it may have been an important part of the ancient port city of Muziris (Muciri Pattinam). Muziris was renowned in both Indian and Greco-Roman sources as a major centre of trade connecting South India with the wider Indian Ocean world. Thus, Pattanam provides valuable insights into the maritime history, urban development, and international trade networks of ancient Kerala.

Vizhinjam Excavation

Vizhinjam is an important archaeological site located in the Thiruvananthapuram district of Kerala. Situated on the coast of the Arabian Sea, Vizhinjam was known by different names in ancient records, including Vilinam, Vilunam, Vilinda, and

Balita. It served as the fortified capital of the Ay dynasty and later came under the control of the Chera, Chola, and Pandya kingdoms between the eighth and twelfth centuries CE.

Archaeological evidence strongly suggests that Vizhinjam may be the ancient port of Balita mentioned in the *Periplus of the Erythraean Sea*, a Greek maritime text written in the first century CE. Its strategic location on the western coast of India enabled it to develop as an important centre of maritime trade and cultural exchange.

Excavations conducted by the University of Kerala have revealed that Vizhinjam was a major international trading port from at least the first century BCE onwards. Archaeologists have discovered numerous artefacts that demonstrate its role in long-distance trade networks connecting South India with West Asia, China, and later Europe. Finds from the site include ancient coins, glass beads, semi-precious stones such as carnelian, and fragments of iron slag, indicating the presence of local craft and metalworking activities.

The excavations have produced artefacts belonging to different historical periods, ranging from the Early Historic to the Late Medieval period. These discoveries provide valuable evidence for understanding the commercial and cultural connections of ancient Kerala.

Important Artefacts Found at Vizhinjam

Rouletted Ware (2nd Century BCE – 2nd Century CE)

Rouletted Ware is a distinctive type of fine pottery decorated with geometric patterns made using a roulette tool. The term was introduced by archaeologist Sir Mortimer Wheeler in 1945 during his excavations at Arikamedu in South India.

The presence of Rouletted Ware at Vizhinjam indicates active trade contacts during the Early Historic period.

Torpedo Jar Sherds (4th–7th Century CE)

Fragments of Torpedo Jars have been discovered at Vizhinjam. These jars were probably produced in Mesopotamia and were commonly used for storing and transporting liquids such as wine and other commodities. Their presence highlights Vizhinjam's commercial links with West Asia.

Turquoise-Glazed Pottery (7th–11th Century CE)

Turquoise-glazed pottery is one of the most widely distributed ceramic types from West Asia. It has been found at many historical ports around the Indian Ocean. Common forms include jars with straight necks, globular bodies, and sloping shoulders. These ceramics demonstrate Vizhinjam's participation in Indian Ocean trade networks.

Chinese Plain White Porcelain (9th Century CE)

Chinese white porcelain is a high-quality ceramic known for its fine texture and translucent appearance. It was first developed during the Tang dynasty in China and later became an important export commodity. Its discovery at Vizhinjam reflects early trade contacts between Kerala and China.

Chinese Celadon Ware (10th–11th Century CE)

Celadon is a type of ceramic characterized by its distinctive jade-green glaze. Originating in China, celadon ware became highly popular across Asia. The presence of celadon at Vizhinjam provides evidence of strong maritime trade relations with East Asia.

Chinese Blue-and-White Porcelain (12th–18th Century CE)

Blue-and-white porcelain is one of the most famous Chinese ceramic traditions. These wares were produced in major kiln centres such as Jingdezhen in Jiangxi Province and kilns in Fujian Province. The examples found at Vizhinjam are generally dated between the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries CE, indicating continued commercial exchanges with China.

Chinese Porcelain Ware (14th–16th Century CE)

Porcelain is a ceramic material produced by firing refined clay at very high temperatures. It gradually evolved in China and later spread throughout East Asia, Europe, and other parts of the world. The discovery of Chinese porcelain at Vizhinjam reflects the port's continued importance in international trade during the medieval period.

European Ceramics (18th–19th Century CE)

Fragments of European ceramics have also been recovered from Vizhinjam. Although porcelain production in Europe began in the late sixteenth century, most major European porcelain industries developed during the eighteenth century. These finds indicate that Vizhinjam remained connected to global trade networks even during the colonial period. (Source- Department of Archaeology, University of kerala)

Historical Significance of Vizhinjam

The archaeological evidence from Vizhinjam demonstrates that it was one of the most important ports on the Malabar Coast. The wide variety of imported ceramics, coins, beads, and other artefacts reveals extensive commercial contacts with West Asia, China, and Europe over many centuries. These findings highlight Vizhinjam's role as a major centre of maritime trade and cultural interaction in the Indian Ocean world.

Part V

Early historic society and Polity

The Early Historic period of South India, which lasted from about 300 BCE to 500 CE, was an important stage in the development of society and political institutions in Kerala and the wider Tamilakam region. During this period, society gradually changed from simple tribal and clan-based communities to more organized and hierarchical social and political systems. A notable feature of this period was the close relationship between society and political authority. Historians reconstruct this period mainly through Sangam literature, archaeological discoveries, inscriptions, and foreign accounts, especially those written by Greco-Roman travellers and traders.

Political organization in early South India was decentralized. Political authority was closely connected to social institutions such as kinship groups, clan networks, and ecological regions. Power was not separated from society through formal state institutions. Instead, it was based on the control of important resources such as land, cattle, and trade.

Economic developments played a major role in these transformations. The expansion of agriculture increased food production and generated surplus wealth. Chiefs gained power by controlling and redistributing this surplus among their followers. As a result, social inequalities and political hierarchies became more pronounced. Maritime trade also contributed significantly to these changes. Contacts with foreign traders brought wealth and prestige to certain rulers, strengthening their political position.

Social Structure

The social structure of early South India was hierarchical, although it was not as rigid as the caste system that developed in later centuries. Social status depended largely on occupation, wealth, and access to resources rather than on strictly hereditary caste divisions.

At the top of society were the ruling elites. These included the **Vendar** (crowned kings) and the **Velir** (powerful chieftains), who controlled resources and exercised political authority. Below them were the **Kizhar**, local chiefs who acted as intermediaries between the rulers and the common people.

Most of the population consisted of agriculturists, pastoralists, artisans, and traders. Agriculture was the main source of wealth, making farmers an important section of society. Pastoralists, who managed cattle, also enjoyed considerable economic significance because cattle represented wealth and status. Artisans and traders contributed to economic growth by producing goods and participating in local and long-distance trade.

Social position was closely linked to the control of resources. Individuals and groups who owned land, cattle, or trade networks generally occupied higher positions in society and enjoyed greater prestige and influence.

Kinship and Clan System

Kinship and clan relationships formed the foundation of early South Indian society and polity. People's social identity was primarily determined by their lineage and family connections. Political authority was also deeply rooted in these kinship ties.

Chiefs derived their legitimacy from their clan affiliations. Leadership was usually hereditary, passing from one generation to the next within the same lineage. However, personal qualities such as bravery, generosity, and military

skill were also important for maintaining authority. Loyalty to a chief was based largely on personal and kinship bonds rather than formal political institutions.

The clan system played an important role in economic life as well. Activities such as agriculture, cattle rearing, and other forms of labour were often organized collectively within kin groups. Such cooperation helped ensure the survival and prosperity of the community.

Kinship networks also connected different levels of political authority. The Kizhar, Velir, and Vendar were linked through relationships of allegiance and tribute. These relationships were strengthened through marriage alliances, gift exchange, and mutual support. Shared ancestry created strong feelings of loyalty and obligation among clan members and helped maintain social cohesion.

Political Organization

The political system of early South India, especially during the Sangam age, was based on kinship and segmentary forms of authority rather than a centralized state. Power was distributed among different levels of chiefs and rulers, creating a flexible political structure.

The Kizhar

The Kizhar were local chiefs who exercised authority over villages and agricultural communities. They supervised farming activities, irrigation works, and land management. Their power depended largely on their control of fertile land and their ability to ensure food production. Kizhars also acted as intermediaries between ordinary people and higher political authorities by collecting tribute and maintaining local order. Although their authority was limited in scale, they played an essential role in the functioning of the political system.

The Velir

The Velir occupied an intermediate position in the political hierarchy. They controlled larger territories consisting of several settlements and ecological zones. Velir chiefs were often involved in warfare, cattle raids, and territorial expansion. Since cattle were a major source of wealth, raids were an important means of acquiring resources.

The Velir maintained warrior groups and armed retainers, which strengthened their political influence. They frequently acted as allies or subordinates of the Vendar, but their loyalties could change according to circumstances. Competition, conflict, and shifting alliances among Velir chiefs were common features of early South Indian politics.

The Vendar

The Vendar, or crowned kings, occupied the highest position in the political hierarchy. They were associated with major ruling dynasties such as the Cheras, Cholas, and Pandyas. Although they controlled extensive territories, their authority was not absolute. Their power depended on maintaining alliances with subordinate chiefs and ensuring the regular flow of tribute.

The Vendar derived strength not only from land ownership but also from control over trade routes and commercial centres. In regions such as Kerala, maritime trade was particularly important. Ports and access to foreign markets increased both the economic resources and political influence of the rulers.

Nature of Political Power

Political power in Early Historic South India was decentralized and flexible. Unlike modern states, there were no fixed territorial boundaries. A ruler's authority extended only as far as his influence and military strength could reach.

As a result, different rulers often made overlapping claims over territories, leading to frequent conflicts and competition.

Warfare was an important aspect of political life. Chiefs and rulers fought battles to expand their influence, acquire resources, and gain prestige. Cattle raids were especially common because cattle were considered an important form of wealth. Success in warfare enhanced a ruler's reputation and strengthened his political position.

Political authority was maintained through systems of tribute and gift exchange. Local chiefs provided resources and support to more powerful rulers, who in return offered protection and recognition. Therefore, political power depended largely on military strength, economic resources, and personal relationships rather than formal administrative institutions.

Historians often describe this system as a chiefdom-based polity. Authority was exercised through networks of kinship, loyalty, and tribute rather than through a centralized bureaucracy. Power radiated outward from the chief and depended on the support of followers and subordinate leaders.

Political power also had an important symbolic dimension. Rulers enhanced their legitimacy through titles, rituals, public ceremonies, and acts of generosity. Fame and reputation were highly valued. Sangam poems frequently praised rulers for their bravery, generosity, and success in warfare. Such recognition increased their prestige and authority.

Another important feature of this political system was the **redistributive economy**. Chiefs collected tribute, gifts, and war booty and redistributed them among their followers. This redistribution helped maintain loyalty and strengthen political bonds. A ruler who failed to reward his followers risked losing their support.

Economy and Society

The economy of Early Historic South India was primarily based on agriculture, but it also included pastoralism, trade, and craft production. These economic activities were closely connected to social organization and political authority.

Agriculture was the main source of wealth. Fertile agricultural regions produced surplus food, which could be controlled by chiefs and rulers. The ability to manage and distribute this surplus strengthened political authority and contributed to the development of social hierarchies.

Pastoralism was another important economic activity. Cattle were not only a source of livelihood but also a symbol of wealth and status. They played a major role in social and political relationships and were often the target of raids and conflicts.

Trade, both local and long-distance, contributed significantly to economic growth. The exchange of goods created opportunities for wealth accumulation and social mobility. As a result, the economy became increasingly diversified and supported the growth of more complex social and political structures.

Control over fertile land became an important basis of social status. Those who possessed land and other productive resources occupied higher positions in society. Over time, dominant social groups, including chiefs and later Brahmins, gained greater influence through their control of land and agricultural production.

Craft production was also an important part of the economy. Skilled artisans produced metal objects, pottery, beads, textiles, and other goods for local use as well as for trade. These industries contributed to economic development and regional specialization.

Evidence of Roman coins discovered in South India suggests the growth of monetization and participation in wider economic networks. The circulation of currency reflects increasing commercial activity and connections with foreign markets.

Trade and Political Growth

Trade played a vital role in transforming the society and polity of Early Historic South India. The region maintained active maritime trade connections with the Roman world and other foreign regions. Through these networks, South India exported valuable products such as spices, pearls, gemstones, ivory, and textiles.

The ports of Kerala became important centers of commercial activity. The wealth generated through trade increased the power and prestige of rulers who controlled these ports and trade routes.

The Chera rulers particularly benefited from maritime commerce. Their control over coastal trade enabled them to accumulate wealth and strengthen their political authority. Trade revenues helped rulers maintain military forces, build alliances, and expand their influence.

Commercial growth also encouraged the development of urban centers. Port towns and market settlements emerged as important economic and cultural hubs. Merchants and traders became increasingly influential and formed a distinct social group within society.

Trade contributed not only to economic prosperity but also to political development. As rulers gained control over trade routes and commercial centers, they were able to extend their authority beyond traditional kinship networks. This process contributed to greater political integration and the gradual emergence of more organized forms of rule.

The growth of port towns such as Muziris (Muchiri) marked the beginning of proto-urbanization in South India. These towns became centers of cultural interaction where people from different regions exchanged goods, ideas, technologies, and customs.

Merchant groups gained economic power and often received privileges from rulers. In some cases, their influence extended into political affairs, demonstrating the growing importance of commerce in society.

Role of Women

Women occupied a relatively visible position in Early Historic South Indian society compared to later periods. Sangam literature contains many references to women's participation in social, economic, and cultural life.

Women were actively involved in household management, agriculture, pastoral activities, and craft production. Their labour contributed significantly to the functioning of the family economy. Literary evidence also suggests that women participated in cultural activities and artistic expression.

Some women achieved fame as poets and intellectuals. The renowned poet Avvaiyar is an important example of women's contribution to literature and culture during this period.

Despite these opportunities, society remained patriarchal. Political leadership and military activities were dominated by men, and women's roles were often defined within the framework of family and kinship.

Marriage, chastity, and family honour were highly valued. However, Sangam literature suggests that women possessed a degree of personal agency in matters of love and marriage. In certain situations, they could choose their partners and express their emotions openly.

Women from elite families sometimes played an important role in politics through marriage alliances. Such marriages helped strengthen relationships between ruling families and served important political purposes.

Over time, however, the growing influence of Brahmanical traditions appears to have introduced greater restrictions on women's social roles, emphasizing domestic responsibilities and ideals of chastity.

Religion and Culture

Religion in Early Historic South India was closely connected to nature, ecology, and local traditions. Religious beliefs reflected the environmental conditions of different regions and formed an important part of everyday life.

The Sangam concept of tinai linked specific landscapes with particular deities and cultural practices. For example, Murugan was associated with hill regions, while Varuna was connected with coastal areas. This relationship between landscape and worship highlights the close connection between environment and belief systems.

Hero worship was another important feature of religious life. Memorial stones known as Nadukal were erected in honour of warriors who died in battle. These hero stones commemorated bravery and sacrifice and reflected the importance of martial values in society.

Hero worship also had a political function. It encouraged loyalty to chiefs and promoted ideals of courage and warrior ethics. Through such practices, rulers and communities reinforced social unity and political authority.

During this period, new religious traditions such as Jainism and Buddhism began to spread in South India. These religions added to the diversity of beliefs and influenced social and cultural life.

Cultural life was vibrant and rich. Poetry, music, oral traditions, and patronage of artists played an important role in society. Sangam literature remains one of the most valuable sources for understanding tvibranthe social values, political institutions, and cultural achievements of Early Historic South India.

Part VI

Muvendar

The term Muvendar (Mu = three; Vendar = crowned kings) refers to the three major ruling dynasties of Early Historic Tamilakam: the Chera, Chola, and Pandya. These dynasties dominated the political landscape of South India during the Sangam Age (c. 300 BCE–300 CE) and continued to play an important role in the subsequent centuries. The concept of the Muvendar occupies a central place in the study of early South Indian polity because it represents the highest level of political authority in Tamilakam.

Knowledge about the Muvendar is derived mainly from Sangam literature, archaeological discoveries, inscriptions, numismatic evidence, and foreign accounts, particularly those of Greek and Roman writers. These sources reveal a society in which political power was closely linked to kinship, warfare, trade, and control over resources.

The Political Position of the Muvendar

The Muvendar stood at the apex of the political hierarchy in Early Historic Tamilakam. They were known as Vendar, or crowned kings, and exercised authority over extensive territories. However, their rule did not resemble the centralized states of later periods. Their power depended on alliances with local chiefs, military strength, and control over economic resources.

The political system of Tamilakam was segmentary in nature. The Muvendar ruled through a network of subordinate chiefs known as Velir and local leaders known as Kizhar. These chiefs collected tribute, maintained local order, and provided military support to the kings. As a result, the authority of the Muvendar rested more on personal loyalty and political alliances than on formal administrative institutions.

The relationship between the Muvendar and subordinate chiefs was dynamic. Chiefs could shift their allegiance from one ruler to another depending on political circumstances. Consequently, warfare, diplomacy, marriage alliances, and gift exchange became essential tools for maintaining authority.

The Cheras

The Cheras ruled the western part of Tamilakam, corresponding largely to present-day Kerala and adjoining regions. Their territory extended from the Western Ghats to the Arabian Sea, giving them access to important maritime trade routes.

The Cheras derived much of their wealth from overseas trade. Ports such as **Muziris** became major centers of commerce connecting South India with the Roman Empire and West Asia. Pepper, spices, ivory, pearls, and precious stones were exported in large quantities.

The prosperity generated by maritime trade strengthened Chera political authority. Sangam texts celebrate several Chera rulers for their military achievements, generosity, and patronage of poets. Their control over trade routes enabled them to accumulate wealth and maintain their position among the Muvendar.

The Cholas

The Cholas ruled the fertile Kaveri River valley in eastern Tamilakam. The region's rich agricultural resources formed the basis of Chola power. The Kaveri delta supported extensive cultivation and generated agricultural surplus, which strengthened the authority of the rulers.

The Cholas also controlled important ports on the Coromandel Coast and participated in maritime trade. Sangam literature describes Chola rulers as powerful warriors who expanded their territories through military campaigns.

The political strength of the Cholas rested on a combination of agricultural prosperity, military organization, and commercial activity. Their control over fertile land enabled them to mobilize resources and maintain large armies.

The Pandyas

The Pandyas ruled the southern region of Tamilakam, with **Madurai** serving as their principal center of power. Madurai emerged as an important political, commercial, and cultural center during the Sangam Age.

The Pandya kingdom benefited from agriculture, inland trade, and maritime commerce. The pearl fisheries of the Gulf of Mannar were an important source of revenue and attracted foreign merchants. Sangam texts portray the Pandya rulers as patrons of literature, religion, and learning.

The Pandyas maintained their influence through military strength and control over strategic trade routes. Like the other members of the Muvendar, their authority depended on alliances with subordinate chiefs and the ability to distribute wealth among followers.

The Warfare

Warfare was a central feature of the political life of the Muvendar. Military success enhanced a ruler's prestige and helped expand his sphere of influence. Sangam literature contains numerous references to battles, cattle raids, and heroic warfare.The objectives of warfare were acquisition of territory, control of trade routes, collection of tribute, capture of cattle and other resources and enhancement of royal prestige.Victory in battle increased a ruler's reputation and strengthened loyalty among followers. Heroic deeds were celebrated in poetry and commemorated through hero stones (Nadukal), which became symbols of martial valor.

Economy

The economic foundations of the Muvendar rested on agriculture, trade, tribute, and warfare. Agricultural surplus enabled rulers to support warriors, officials, and dependents. Trade provided additional wealth and connected Tamilakam to wider economic networks.

Foreign trade, especially with the Roman Empire, played a particularly significant role. Roman coins discovered in South India demonstrate the intensity of commercial contacts. The import of gold and luxury goods increased the wealth of ruling elites and enhanced their political authority.

The Muvendar operated within a redistributive economic system. Tribute, gifts, and booty collected by rulers were redistributed among warriors, poets, and subordinate chiefs. This redistribution created bonds of loyalty and reinforced political relationships.

Muvendar and Sangam Literature

The Muvendar are prominently featured in Sangam literature. Poets praised kings for their bravery, generosity, military victories, and patronage. Royal courts

became centers of literary activity, where poets received rewards in return for their compositions.

Sangam poems provide valuable information about political institutions, warfare, economic life, and social values. They also reveal the importance of reputation and honor in maintaining political authority. A ruler's fame was considered an essential component of kingship.

The patronage extended by the Muvendar contributed significantly to the development of Tamil literary traditions and cultural life.

Historians have offered different interpretations of the political role of the Muvendar. Earlier scholars often viewed them as rulers of organized kingdoms resembling later states. More recent historians argue that Sangam-age polity was segmentary and chiefdom-based rather than fully centralized.

According to this interpretation, the Muvendar exercised influence through networks of kinship, tribute, and military alliances rather than through bureaucratic institutions. Their authority was real but often limited by the autonomy of local chiefs and the fluid nature of territorial boundaries.

Despite these limitations, the Muvendar represented an important stage in the evolution of political organization in South India. Their rule laid the foundations for the emergence of more centralized states in later centuries.

Part VII

Kurunila Mannar

The term Kurunila Mannar refers to the minor chieftains or local rulers who occupied an important position in the political structure of Early Historic

Tamilakam during the Sangam Age (c. 300 BCE–300 CE). The word *kurunila* means "small territory" and *mannar* means "king" or "ruler." Thus, Kurunila Mannar were rulers of relatively small regions who exercised authority over local communities and resources.

Although they did not possess the power and prestige of the three crowned kings (Muvendar)—the Cheras, Cholas, and Pandyas—the Kurunila Mannar played a vital role in the political, economic, and social life of ancient Tamil society. Sangam literature contains numerous references to these local chiefs, highlighting their military exploits, generosity, and relationships with larger kingdoms.

Position in the Political Hierarchy

The political system of Sangam-age Tamilakam was not a centralized state. Instead, it consisted of a network of rulers organized in a hierarchical structure. At the highest level were the Muvendar, while below them were the Kurunila Mannar, who controlled smaller territories.

These chiefs exercised considerable autonomy within their regions. Some acknowledged the authority of the Chera, Chola, or Pandya kings and paid tribute to them, while others functioned independently. Their political position often depended on military strength, control over resources, and strategic alliances.

The Kurunila Mannar acted as intermediaries between local communities and larger political authorities. They maintained order, collected tribute, supervised agricultural activities, and protected their territories from external threats.

Territorial Basis of Power

The authority of the Kurunila Mannar was generally based on control over a specific geographical region. Their territories varied in size and often included villages, agricultural lands, forests, grazing grounds, and trade routes.

Unlike modern states with clearly defined boundaries, the territories of the Kurunila Mannar were fluid and constantly changing. Political influence depended more on personal authority and military power than on fixed territorial control. As a result, conflicts between neighbouring chiefs were common.

The ecological diversity of Tamilakam also shaped the character of local chiefdoms. Chiefs ruling fertile agricultural areas possessed greater economic resources, while those in pastoral or forest regions depended more heavily on cattle wealth and forest products.

Military Functions

Warfare was one of the most important responsibilities of the Kurunila Mannar. Military success enhanced their prestige and strengthened their political position. Sangam poems frequently describe local chiefs as brave warriors who defended their territories and led their followers into battle.

Cattle raids were a common feature of warfare. Since cattle represented wealth and status, the capture of cattle from rival groups was an important means of acquiring resources. Successful military campaigns increased a chief's reputation and attracted loyal followers.

The Kurunila Mannar maintained warrior groups and military retainers who formed the backbone of their power. Loyalty between chiefs and warriors was reinforced through rewards, gifts, and shared participation in warfare.

Economic Foundations

The economic power of the Kurunila Mannar rested on agriculture, pastoralism, tribute, and trade. Agricultural production provided food and surplus resources that could be used to support warriors and dependents.

Control over fertile land was a major source of wealth. Chiefs often supervised irrigation works, land use, and agricultural production within their territories. In pastoral regions, cattle served as an important measure of wealth and social status.

Many local chiefs also benefited from trade. Those located near trade routes, market centers, or ports were able to collect taxes and tribute from commercial activities. The growth of long-distance trade during the Sangam Age enhanced the economic importance of some chiefdoms.

Relationship with the Muvendar

The relationship between the Kurunila Mannar and the Muvendar was complex and constantly changing. Some chiefs accepted the supremacy of the Chera, Chola, or Pandya rulers and paid tribute to them. In return, they received military protection and political recognition.

However, the authority of the Muvendar was often limited. Powerful local chiefs could challenge royal authority, form alliances with rival rulers, or maintain considerable independence. Political loyalty was therefore flexible and based on mutual benefit rather than strict subordination.

Marriage alliances, gift exchange, and military cooperation helped maintain relations between local chiefs and larger kingdoms. These connections formed the basis of the segmentary political system characteristic of Early Historic Tamilakam.

Patronage and Cultural Life

The Kurunila Mannar were important patrons of literature and culture. Sangam poets frequently visited their courts and composed poems praising their bravery, generosity, and hospitality. In return, poets received gifts such as gold, cattle, land, and other rewards.

The support provided by local chiefs contributed significantly to the development of Sangam literature. Many poems celebrate the virtues of famous Kurunila Mannar and provide valuable information about their political and social role.

Generosity was considered an essential quality of leadership. A chief's reputation depended not only on military achievements but also on his willingness to distribute wealth among followers, poets, and guests.

Famous Kurunila Mannar

Sangam literature mentions several renowned Kurunila Mannar who became famous for their courage and generosity.

Pari

Pari was one of the most celebrated chieftains of the Sangam Age. He ruled the Parambu region and became famous for his generosity. Literary traditions describe him as a ruler who willingly shared his wealth with poets and the needy. He resisted the combined power of the Chera, Chola, and Pandya kings and became a symbol of independence and heroism.

Ori

Ori ruled the Kolli Hills and was renowned for his military skill and generosity. Sangam poems portray him as a brave warrior and a patron of poets.

Adiyaman Neduman Anji

Adiyaman was an influential chief of Tagadur. He is remembered for his friendship with the poet Avvaiyar and for his patronage of literature. His rule demonstrates the close relationship between political authority and cultural life.

Nalli and Pegan

These chiefs are also remembered in Sangam literature for their generosity, bravery, and patronage of poets. Together with Pari, Ori, and Adiyaman, they are often included among the famous philanthropic rulers of the Sangam Age.

Historians have interpreted the Kurunila Mannar in different ways. Earlier scholars often viewed them simply as subordinate chiefs under the Muvendar. More recent studies emphasize their autonomy and importance within the segmentary political structure of Early Historic Tamilakam.

Scholars argue that political authority was dispersed among numerous local chiefdoms rather than concentrated in a centralized state. The Kurunila Mannar controlled resources, mobilized military forces, and maintained social order within their territories. Their role was therefore crucial in understanding the nature of early South Indian polity.

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Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

1. Sangam literature is generally dated between:

A. 1000 BCE – 500 BCE
B. 300 BCE – 300 CE
C. 500 CE – 1000 CE
D. 1200 CE – 1500 CE

Answer: B. 300 BCE – 300 CE

2. Which of the following is an example of Akam literature?

A. Purananuru
B. Pathitrupathu
C. Akananuru
D. Manimegalai

Answer: C. Akananuru

3. The presiding deity of the Kurinji landscape is:

A. Indra
B. Varuna
C. Mayon
D. Murugan

Answer: D. Murugan

4. Which landscape is associated with agriculture and fertile river valleys?

A. Mullai
B. Marutam
C. Neital
D. Palai

Answer: B. Marutam

5. The author of *Thirukkural* is:

A. Tolkappiyar
B. Ilango Adigal
C. Thiruvalluvar
D. Sattanar

Answer: C. Thiruvalluvar

6. Which Greco-Roman text provides detailed information about Muziris and Nelcynda?

A. Geographia
B. Natural History
C. Periplus of the Erythraean Sea
D. Indica

Answer: C. Periplus of the Erythraean Sea

7. Pattanam is widely identified with the ancient port of**:**

A. Arikamedu
B. Korkai
C. Muziris
D. Nelcynda

Answer: C. Muziris

8. The term Muvendar refers to:

A. Three major ports
B. Three religious traditions
C. Three crowned kings
D. Three literary academies

Answer: C. Three crowned kings

9. Which among the following was a famous Kurunila Mannar known for ruling Parambu?

A. Pegan
B. Ori

C. Pari
D. Nalli

Answer: C. Pari

10. Hero stones erected in memory of fallen warriors were known as:

A. Menhirs
B. Dolmens
C. Nadukal
D. Cairns

Answer: C. Nadukal

Short Essay Questions

1.Discuss the major features and classifications of Sangam literature.

2.Explain the concept of Tinai and its significance in understanding early Tamil society.

3.Evaluate the importance of Greco-Roman writings for reconstructing the history of early Keralam.

4.Describe the major archaeological findings from Pattanam and their historical significance.

5.Examine the political hierarchy of Early Historic Tamilakam with reference to Kizhar, Velir, and Vendar.

Essay Questions

1.Critically examine the social, economic, political, and cultural features of Early Historic South Indian society (300 BCE–500 CE).

2.Discuss the political organization, economy, warfare, and historical significance of the Muvendar in Early Historic Tamilakam.

3.Analyse the role of the Kurunila Mannar in the political structure of Sangam-age Tamilakam, highlighting their military, economic, and cultural contributions.